

Q. Involving clients in this process increases the chances of their adopting the idea of conducting a similar contest. How does this work? Do you have the confidence or a strong relationship to prevent this from happening?

A. First, let me share our definition of trust, which is competence and character. We approach our clients and partners for participation in the contest with clear guidelines laid out in terms of their roles, responsibilities, and takeaways. We are transparent and collaborative in our approach. Also, Cloud 20/20 is an 11-year-old platform with deep connects in academia. Our relationship with many of the participating institutes goes beyond this contest. We have full faith in the quality of the contest and the bond we have established with academia over the years.

Q. What happens to IP, especially in TIP? Is there an exchange of IP in such cases?

A. At the start of the relationship, when the students are registered, it is declared that the IP belongs to Unisys, as we are taking the lead in the ecosystem. Also, at the stage of funnelling down the teams, we make an explicit declaration that the IP belongs to Unisys. This helps in ensuring transparency. Talking about innovative ideas and their deployment, we talk to our clients and come up with a suitable decision as to where the IP belongs.

Q. Can you share any success stories where the solution has been given and implemented for a problem statement?

A. This is a new initiative, and we started functioning about two years ago. Though we have great partners and we had good problem statements

as well, the solutions could not be implemented due to Covid-19. We are hopeful that in the years to come, a few of these solutions will be implemented.

Q. The name Cloud 20/20 was decided twelve years back. What was the thought behind the name?

A. Almost everything that we do nowadays is based on cloud technology. Twelve years ago, we knew that this cloud system is going to be the future of technological developments. In the western context, 20 by 20 means perfect eyesight, so by this programme and academia, we wanted to provide customers a clear vision of cloud and cloud-based services. Cloud is a metaphor for emerging technologies, and the programme 20 by 20 is also a driving force for us as we want to keep making it clearer.

Q. What came first— the SIP or TIP?

A. SIP came first. Initially, it started as a technical paper contest. Then we shifted it to a demonstrable project contest, where the contestant needs to write an abstract, develop a prototype, and then demonstrate it to our technical panel. After this, we were questioning ourselves as to what we can do next, and then we came up with the TIP part of the programme.

Q. The award money for SIP and TIP is 425,000 rupees; so how is it divided between the two different challenges?

A. The judgment is based on who provides a better solution to the problem and where will it be good to invest money. The money is awarded to three teams; the combination does not matter to us, but the kind of solution matters. In rare cases, there is a tie between teams, and in such

cases, we either split the money or introduce another award.

Q. How many of your employees get allocated to assist with the projects?

A. Roughly about five per cent of the employees are allocated to help with the projects. The engineers are not fully invested in the projects as their role is just to provide mentorship to the students and, in the end, the student has to complete it himself/herself.

Q. Besides this competition, are there any other platforms to engage with academia and students?

A. Yes, we do have a dedicated programme called UTFI, which can be accessed through the website called *utfi.co.in*. Through this, a student can apply for internships. This is the primary platform for our academia. Here we have uploaded some technical webinars, the latest technology trends, information about the contests, and other relevant information. This is not a charged service and anyone can access it.

Q. What are the challenges and opportunities that you are seeing during the pandemic regarding the hiring of candidates?

A. Our IT and recruitment teams worked really well during this pandemic, and they found out solutions very quickly to deal with the scenario. Now we interview candidates through digital mediums such as phone calls, interacting through video calls, learning through videos, etc. We were still hiring throughout the pandemic, and there was no change in the recruitment strategy; only the medium of recruitment was changed.

Continued on page 17....